a pocket field guide to

WILD ERRORS

how to spot & identify the numbers that pop up when the web has something to tell you

field guides to the digital wild · no. 2

my sightings

- ☐ 200 (so common nobody looks twice)
- ☐ 301 ☐ 403 ☐ 503
- ☐ 404 (if you spotted one, you didn't.)
- ☐ 418 (rare!)
- ☐ _____ (go find more.)

if you meet one:
4xx: check what you asked for, and whether you're allowed.
5xx: it's not you. wait, then try again.

made with ink & a slow connection
after RFC 9110, 2022 & RFC 2324, 1998
by jerry gay

cut along the dashes

field notes: the rarest one

april 1, 1998. someone wrote a serious-looking standard for brewing coffee over the internet. ask a teapot for coffee and it answers:

418, i'm a teapot.

in 2017, engineers tried to remove it. people protested until it stayed. today it's officially reserved: a protected species.

the 503

Servus hibernans

too tired, too busy, or out for maintenance. leave it alone and it's usually back by morning. (poking it makes it grumpier.)

habitat: launch days, the minute tickets go on sale

catch difficulty: ★★☆☆☆
(just wait)

the 403

Clientus prohibitus

guards the gate. its cousin the 401 asks "who are you?" the 403 knows exactly who you are. the answer is still no.

habitat: admin pages, the cookie jar

catch difficulty: don't. it's doing its job.

the 404

Clientus absens

you've seen its sign a hundred times. but go looking for the page and you only find the spot where it should be. (it isn't hiding. there's just nothing there.)

habitat: links from 2004, typos

catch difficulty: ☆☆☆☆☆
(nothing to catch)

the 301

Redirectus migratorius

flew away and never came back. but it's polite: it leaves a note saying where it went, and your browser follows without a word.

habitat: old addresses, sites that moved to https

catch difficulty: ★☆☆☆☆
(it tells you where it went)

how to identify

every one of them carries a number. look at the first digit: it tells you the family.

2 happy. it worked.
3 migratory. it moved.
4 the problem's on your side.
5 the server tripped.

(1xx are the larvae. you'll almost never see one.)